Parshas Miketz

The Light That Refuses to Blend In

Yosef · Bitachon · Pirsumei Nisa · Jewish Identity

I. A Convergence of Holiness

What a powerful time we are entering: Erev Shabbos, Miketz, Chanukah, and Rosh Chodesh, all stacking on top of one another. As a reminder, we say the longest Birkas HaMazon of the year right now, because of all the additions: Yaaleh V'Yavo, Al HaNissim, and of course Shabbos itself. It is a beautiful, layered time, and our responsibility grows alongside all that holiness converging at once.

II. Two More Years in Prison

We see that it is finally time for Yosef HaTzaddik to be freed after his long imprisonment. But the commentaries are careful to note something important about how that freedom actually came. Although Yosef never stopped speaking about Hashem, he also asked for human intervention, requesting that the Sar HaMashkim remember him to Pharaoh:

Please remember me. Mention me to Pharaoh and ask him to let me out.

There was still a subtle level of reliance on human beings rather than complete trust in Hashem. The commentaries explain that had Yosef simply continued his avodah, continued davening, and relied fully on Hashem without worrying about the mechanism of his own salvation, this additional predicament would not have arisen. Instead, he remained in prison for two more years, learning an even deeper lesson in humility and bitachon.

Why emphasize humility specifically? Because we should remember how Yosef ended up in this situation to begin with. Earlier in his life he was known for speaking critically about his brothers, bringing reports back to Yaakov. He also openly shared his dreams, earning the reputation of the dreamer. Now, years later, including those additional two years in prison, something has genuinely changed in him.

III. Standing Before Pharaoh

Yosef is suddenly brought before Pharaoh. Pharaoh has disturbing dreams that none of his advisers can interpret. He is told about a young Hebrew man sitting in prison, known for correctly interpreting dreams. At that time, being identified as a Hebrew was certainly not considered an honor. Yet Yosef now has the opportunity to demonstrate something not only to Pharaoh, but to the entire world.

He shows that a Jew can stand with dignity. A Jew can dress properly. A Jew can demonstrate wisdom, intelligence, and understanding. A Jew can contribute to the world without arrogance.

The Midrash teaches something fascinating here. When Yosef stood before Pharaoh, he spoke with him in every language Pharaoh knew. Then Yosef whispered one additional language into Pharaoh's ear, a language Pharaoh himself did not know. According to the Midrash, the law in Egypt was that the ruler had to know every language spoken within the kingdom. If someone knew more languages than Pharaoh, that person would technically have a greater claim to leadership.

Think about the contrast. Earlier in Yosef's life, one of his struggles was presenting truth without sufficient humility. Even when the message itself was true, he had not yet learned how to communicate it with proper tznius. Now we finally see that growth. Instead of publicly exposing Pharaoh's limitation and embarrassing him, Yosef quietly whispers that final language into his ear. In effect he says: I want you to know that I know this, but I am not going to use it against you. He protects Pharaoh's dignity. That is genuine humility.

When Pharaoh asks Yosef to interpret the dreams, Yosef immediately responds:

בִּלְעָדַי אֱלֹקִים יַעֲנֶה אֶת שְׁלוֹם פַּרְעֹה

"It is not me. Hashem will answer Pharaoh's welfare."

— Bereishis 41:16

Yosef gives no credit to himself. Everything is attributed to Hashem. Only then does he explain the dreams and immediately turn to the practical solution: prepare now, store grain during the years of abundance, and ensure there will be food during the years of famine.

IV. Teshuvah Tested a Second Time

From there, the story continues as we know it. Yosef is elevated to a position of leadership, and eventually he is reunited with his brothers. Although the full reconciliation does not take place until next week's parsha, throughout Miketz Yosef has the opportunity to see his brothers again. He tests them. He interacts with them. He places them in situations that reveal whether they have truly changed.

This is an incredibly important perspective because it teaches us about teshuvah. The Rambam explains that complete teshuvah is demonstrated when a person faces the very same situation a second time and chooses differently. That is how we know the change is real.

We see this in Yosef himself. He has already undergone his own process of growth. The way he now addresses Pharaoh is completely different from the way he conducted himself in his youth. Everything he says points back to Hashem. Everything he does reflects humility. But we also see the brothers being tested. When Binyamin enters the picture, the question becomes: will they treat him the same way they treated Yosef? Will they abandon another brother? Will jealousy and division once again tear the family apart? We know that next week we will see the completion of that process, and we will discover that they have changed. They will not repeat the mistakes of the past. That is what genuine teshuvah looks like.

V. Masters of Time

Now we can connect all of this to the other dimensions of this Shabbos: Shabbos itself, Chanukah, and Rosh Chodesh.

Rosh Chodesh was one of the very first mitzvos given to Klal Yisrael as a nation. Hashem entrusted us with sanctifying time itself. We declare the new month. We become partners with Hashem in establishing the calendar. In that sense, we become masters of time, not because we control creation, but because Hashem gave us the responsibility of sanctifying it.

We actually live with two calendars. There is the Jewish calendar, which governs our mitzvos, our Yamim Tovim, and our spiritual lives. There is also the civil calendar that the rest of the world follows for everyday purposes. Even within halacha there are practical interactions with both systems.

VI. Which One Is Your Real Birthday?

That brings me to a conversation I had this week at work. One of my colleagues is Jewish and was raised in Turkey. We were discussing birthdays and different calendars. Those who know me know that, for me, the Jewish calendar is always the primary one. My birthday is in Elul. My wife's birthday is in Adar. My father's birthday is in Elul. Our anniversary is according to the Jewish calendar. My children were born according to the Jewish calendar. These are the dates that matter most to me.

During the conversation she asked me: which one is your real birthday? It was an interesting question because of the way she had been raised. I gently corrected her. I told her: my real birthday is the one on the Jewish calendar. If you want to know the date the rest of the world uses, I can tell you that too. But my real birthday is the day according to the calendar Hashem gave us. She smiled, and we ended up having a wonderful conversation about what that actually means.

As Jews, we are meant to live according to the calendar Hashem entrusted to us. Rosh Chodesh, the declaration of the months, the festivals, and even the leap years all demonstrate that responsibility. Our calendar keeps the Yamim Tovim aligned with the seasons exactly as the Torah requires. Other calendar systems function differently. The Islamic calendar moves throughout the seasons because it is purely lunar. Even the Gregorian calendar requires periodic correction through leap years to stay aligned with the solar year. The Jewish calendar, however, reflects both the physical reality of creation and the spiritual mission Hashem gave to Klal Yisrael. It constantly reminds us that our relationship with time is different because our relationship with Hashem is different.

VII. What Chanukah Is Not About

The second story is, unfortunately, connected to what happened this week in Australia. We all know about the events that took place, and we should not ignore them, whitewash them, or minimize their significance. There was an attack during a public Chanukah event. People had gathered to celebrate Chanukah openly, to perform the mitzvah of pirsumei nisa, publicizing the miracle, and to help fellow Jews reconnect with their heritage and their Yiddishkeit.

Chanukah is one of the most important times of the year in that regard. It is not simply about the parties, the presents, or the celebrations. There is a message that is often forgotten. Many people think the message of Chanukah is simply: let's all get along, accept me for who I am and I will accept you for who you are. That sounds beautiful on the surface, but it misses the central message of Chanukah. That framing can eventually blur boundaries. It can lead toward unhealthy integration and assimilation. It can suggest that our differences do not really matter.

But that is not what Chanukah teaches. The message of Chanukah is to remain true to who we are. Do not surrender your identity simply because the surrounding culture says something has become normal. Just because something becomes common does not make it correct. I remember my father asking me when I was younger: if all your friends jumped off a bridge, would you jump too? Of course, I have some friends who actually do jump off bridges safely as part of organized activities, so the example is a little amusing today. But that was never the point. The point was simple: do not follow the crowd simply because everyone else is doing something. The world today constantly pressures us to conform. If we forget who we are, we forget that Hashem created us with a unique purpose.

VIII. Seeing Ourselves Through Torah's Eyes, Not the World's

That brings me back to my colleague. She is Jewish, but she was raised in Turkey with a very different perspective. She sincerely believed the secular calendar was the real one. It reminded me how easily we can begin seeing ourselves through someone else's worldview instead of through the Torah's worldview.

As Jews, we must remember that we are different. That is not a statement of superiority. It is a statement of purpose. Part of that purpose is that we have our own calendar. This is our calendar. This is the way Hashem instructed us to measure time. Part of that purpose is also recognizing that we are not meant simply to blend into every surrounding culture. That is one of the central messages of Chanukah. If we forget that message, history repeatedly shows us what can happen.

IX. More Than Ever

That is why the events in Australia struck so deeply. The day after hearing the news, a friend and I were walking to the train station. He asked me: do you think Chabad will

continue holding these public Chanukah events now that they have become more dangerous? I answered: more than ever.

We cannot allow physical threats to stop us from carrying out the mission Hashem gave us. Our bodies and our neshamah are connected, but they are not the same. Our neshamah is eternal. Hashem placed us into this physical world to reveal His presence within it. If fear causes us to hide that mission, then something precious has already been lost. History has shown us that surrendering our identity does not ultimately bring safety anyway. Even during the Spanish Inquisition, there were Jews who converted outwardly, yet they were still persecuted and killed. The lesson has never been: conform and you will be safe. The lesson is to remain faithful to Hashem regardless of the pressures around us.

X. Look at What Hashem Enables

We have to remember our priorities. We are here to carry Hashem's message into the world. We are not here simply to be ordinary people. When Yosef stood before Pharaoh, he understood that. He did not say: look at me, look at this Hebrew who has all the answers. Instead, he said: look at what Hashem enables me to do. Look at what Hashem has given me. Look at the wisdom that comes from Hashem.

All of Pharaoh's advisers, all of those who practiced idolatry and sought answers through their own systems, could not interpret the dreams. But Hashem ensured that His messenger would be there to deliver the correct message at the proper time. That is Yosef's greatness.

XI. A Ray of Light, Not the Sun Itself

As we enter Chanukah, we remember that we are called to be a light unto the nations. Not by becoming indistinguishable from the nations. Rather, by remaining faithful to who we are. Our neshamah shines precisely because it is connected to Hashem.

A ray of sunlight inside the sun cannot illuminate anything around it. Only when that ray extends outward does it bring light to the world. So too, we must shine. We must bring Torah into the world. But we must never lose sight of where that light comes from. We do not assimilate. We do not surrender our identity. We do not say: I will simply become like everyone else. Instead, we proudly say: I am a Jew. I am part of Hashem's people.

We have survived every empire that attempted to erase us. We have witnessed generation after generation of those who sought to destroy us, yet we remain. The lesson of history is not that we should conform in order to survive. Very often, those who sought acceptance through assimilation discovered that acceptance was never truly granted. Instead, we remain committed to Torah, to mitzvos, and to our unique mission.

XII. Our Response Is Our Mission

We should also remember that the nations of the world are fulfilling the roles Hashem gave them. The question is not what they will do. The question is what we will do. How will we respond? Will we strengthen our observance? Will we perform more mitzvos? Will we bring more Torah into the world? Will we strengthen our Jewish identity? That is our response. That is our mission.

We are not here simply to be another nation among the nations. We are here to illuminate the world with Hashem's light. May we merit, through the lights of Chanukah, to continue shining that light until the rebuilding of the Beis HaMikdash HaShlishi, when the Menorah will once again illuminate the entire world.

חזק ואחזק

Shabbat Shalom, Chanukah Sameach, and Chodesh Tov

Reflection Questions

- *Where in my own life have I relied on a human backup plan rather than placing full trust in Hashem, the way Yosef did with the Sar HaMashkim? What did that cost me in waiting?*
- *Like Yosef before Pharaoh, where do I have an opportunity to demonstrate something true without embarrassing or exposing someone else in the process?*
- *Have I faced the same test twice and responded differently the second time? What did that actually look like in practice?*
- *Do I instinctively measure my life, my milestones, my sense of what is real, according to the Jewish calendar, or have I absorbed the world's calendar without noticing?*
- *Where in my life am I tempted to blur a boundary because the surrounding culture calls it normal? What would it mean to hold that boundary anyway?*
- *In the face of real fear, like the fear following Australia, am I shining my light more or retreating into smaller, safer spaces? What is my own answer to more than ever?*